Somehow, I managed to condense twelve years of international cricket, and a lifetime of support, into a 395-word retirement statement, released from Lord's at noon the following day. I tried to capture my pride, my sense of purpose and the pragmatism of the player who knows it is time to go. I expressed my gratitude to my mentor, Goochy, and to the Barmy Army, but above all to my family. They are the constant in a cricketer's life, the foundation on which so much can be built.

The response was humbling, uniformly warm and respectful. I don't care what anyone says, when you are reading nice things about yourself for two or three days straight it creates a weird sense of detachment; it's almost an out-of-body experience. It felt like I was reading my obituary – one of my friends even texted me, asking, 'Are you dead?'

I played golf with Jimmy at Woburn before we reported to the Oval for the final Test. He grabbed a photo of me sitting in an armchair in the clubhouse, reading a newspaper article with the headline: 'Cook the Modern Legend Calls It a Day'. Inevitably, the image was posted on his Instagram account with the comment: 'The thing I love most about Cookie is that he has absolutely no ego.'

Ed Smith, the England national selector, had called during the round to check I was still in the right frame of mind to play in the last Test. I hope he excuses the white lie I told at the time, to cover up the reality that I was struggling with the fear of letting people down. The build-up was surreal, since everything, from the last net to the valedictory press conference, had an element of finality.

People were kind, considerate, and unwittingly challenging. 'Just go out and enjoy it,' they told me. 'It doesn't matter how many runs you get.' Well, sorry, but it did. Cricket is one of the only sports where you are primarily defined by your statistics. Runs are your currency, and the thought of ending with a pair in my last Test made me more nervous than at any time in the previous 160.

I was driven back to the standards I set myself, the fear of failure that spurred me to perform constantly under pressure. That desperation to do well, dealing with anxiety created by the expectations of people you will probably never meet, takes its toll mentally. Did that process involve a degree of self-worth? I honestly don't know, but I needed to live up to the numbers.